

A Question Worth Asking

A reflection on music, the heart, and what it means to love Allah

Music has become so woven into the fabric of our lives that we rarely stop to question it. It wakes us up in the morning, accompanies us on long drives, fills the silence while we study, comforts us when we're hurting, and celebrates with us when we're happy. For many of us, it has become less of an activity and more of a companion. Something that is always there. Something we instinctively reach for. But perhaps that is exactly why it deserves to be questioned.

Some of the most influential things in our lives are the ones we hardly notice anymore. We often ask whether music is permissible or impermissible. We debate rulings, quote scholars, and argue over differences of opinion. But have we even asked ourselves: **“What does music even mean for us? What does it do for us? What does it do to us?”** If not, then you are at the right place right now, my fellow akh/ukhti.

Many of us have heard countless times that music is haram, but we often dismiss the following fact. Why? Maybe because we don't understand the wisdom behind this command, or we don't have that love in our hearts for Allah SWT to obey what He said. If I am being honest here, I don't even really blame you, because usually we are always taught to fear Allah SWT and barely ever to love. So before jumping into any commands, I just want to discuss a few things with you as a sister.

Before starting, I'd like to make dua that whatever I write now benefits you and me. Ameen, summa ameen.

What Does It Mean to Love Allah? And Why Should We Even Love Allah?

Think about your very first breath. Before anyone knew your name, before you had earned anything, before you had done a single good deed, Allah had already chosen life for you. He designed every detail of you with wisdom—the colour of your eyes, the rhythm of your heartbeat, the family you were born into, and every moment that would shape your journey. You are not an accident. You are a deliberate creation of a Lord who creates with purpose.

Every morning you wake up, your heart continues beating without your permission. Your lungs continue breathing while you sleep. Your blood flows through thousands of miles of vessels every single day. We rarely stop to think about it because these blessings are constant. Yet every heartbeat is a silent reminder that Allah is sustaining us every second. If He withheld His mercy a moment, none of us could survive.

Look around you. The sky does not collapse upon us. The sun rises with incredible precision. Rain falls exactly where Allah wills. Tiny seeds split open beneath the earth and become towering trees that provide shade, food, and beauty. Every leaf, every mountain, every ocean, and every star is a sign pointing toward its Creator. The universe is not random—it is a masterpiece constantly introducing us to Allah.

The same Lord who created Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) is our Lord. Allah is the One who took care of us even when we failed to obey Him. He is the One who saw the good in us even when we failed to find something good in ourselves. Allah is the One who sees us without us having to perform, the One who hears every whisper, every silent thought, every sob. He sees. He hears.

I Want You to Think About This

Has there ever been a moment in your life when you thought that now there is no way out—where death seemed a more feasible option than being alive—when your family and friends left you, and you were alone, on your own? Who was there? **Allah**. Who took you out? **Allah**. Who took care of you? **Allah**. Who made sure you had food to eat and clothes to wear? **Allah**. He was there, even when you forgot about Him, even when you disobeyed Him not once, but a million times. You make one small mistake and people leave. The creation leaves, but the One who doesn't need anyone, who is neither begotten nor begets, says: *"Oh My slave."* I am repeating—He says *"Oh My slave,"* not *"Oh sinner,"* not *"Oh fulaan,"* not *"Oh insaan."* He still calls you His, so lovingly. He says:

"Say, 'O My servants who have transgressed against themselves [by sinning], do not despair of the mercy of Allah. Indeed, Allah forgives all sins. Indeed, it is He who is the All-Forgiving, the Most Merciful.'"

Surah Az-Zumar, Qur'an 39:53

How could we not love such a Lord? How?

Allah SWT is our Lord, who loves us more than our mothers, so many more times. We often don't get why our mothers scold us at times, or ask us not to do such a thing. Like for the longest of times (and still), my mom keeps asking me not to use my phone so much. You know, the typical mom style:

Me: "Amma, my foot is hurting."

Mom: "Beta, it's the phone."

And maybe if I do really think about it, it is the phone that is the issue.

My mom always wanted to protect me, even at times I couldn't understand the harm. The same way, why would the One who created us want to put unnecessary restrictions on us? If Allah SWT has called something haram, it is only for our own good. As I like to say: **the haram is always gonna do harm.**

Reflection: He Never Stops Knowing

Think about your very first breath. Before anyone knew your name, before you had earned anything, before you had done a single good deed, Allah had already chosen life for you. He designed every detail of you with wisdom—the colour of your eyes, the rhythm of your heartbeat, the family you were born into, and every moment that would shape your journey. You are not an accident. You are a deliberate creation of a Lord who creates with perfect wisdom.

Every morning you wake up, your heart continues beating without your permission. Your lungs continue breathing while you sleep. Your blood flows through thousands of miles of blood vessels every single day. We rarely stop to think about it because these blessings are constant. Yet every heartbeat is a silent reminder that Allah is sustaining us every second. If He withheld His mercy for even a moment, none of us could survive.

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The same Lord who created Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) is our Lord. The same Lord who spoke to Musa (AS), who saved Nuh (AS), who answered the du'a of Yunus (AS) in the darkness of the whale—that very same Allah is your Allah.

He is the One who took care of you even when you failed to obey Him. The One who continued blessing you despite knowing every sin you had committed. The One who sees you without you having to perform for Him. The One who hears every whisper, every silent thought, every sob that never leaves your lips.

He sees. He hears. And He never stops knowing.

I want you to think about this. Has there ever been a moment in your life where you genuinely believed there was no way out? A moment when your heart was so heavy that living itself felt unbearable? A time when everyone seemed to leave you—friends drifted away, family couldn't understand, and you felt completely alone?

Who was there? **Allah.** Who carried you through it? **Allah.** Who made sure your heart kept beating? **Allah.** Who still provided food for your table, clothes on your back, air in your lungs, and another sunrise to witness? **Allah.**

He was there even when you forgot Him. Even when you disobeyed Him. Not once. Not twice. But countless times.

People leave after one mistake. People stop talking to you. People give up on you. But Allah—the One who is completely free of all needs, the One who *“neither begets nor is born”* (Surah Al-Ikhlās)—still calls you with love.

He doesn't say, “O sinner.” He doesn't say, “O failure.” He says:

“Say, ‘O My servants who have transgressed against themselves [by sinning], do not despair of the mercy of Allah. Indeed, Allah forgives all sins. Indeed, it is He who is the All-Forgiving, the Most Merciful.’”

Qur'an 39:53

Read that again. *“O My servants...”* Even after all their sins. Even after all their mistakes. He still calls them His.

How could we not love such a Lord? How?

The Prophet (PBUH) once asked the companions after seeing a mother desperately searching for her child. When she finally found him, she held him tightly and began nursing him. The Prophet (PBUH) asked, *“Do you think this woman would throw her child into the Fire?”* They replied, *“No, by Allah.”* He then said, *“Allah is more merciful to His servants than this mother is to her child.”* (Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim).

Think about your own mother. How many times has she stopped you from doing something you wanted? For the longest time—and honestly, even now—my mum keeps telling me to stay off my phone.

Me: “Ammma, my foot is hurting.”

Her: “Beta, it’s the phone.”

Typical desi mum, right? I used to laugh it off. But maybe... just maybe... she’s right. She isn’t trying to ruin my life. She’s trying to protect it. She sees dangers that I don’t.

And if that’s the love and concern of someone who is only a creation of Allah, then what about the Creator Himself? Why would the One who created us place restrictions on us except out of His perfect wisdom and mercy? Allah does not make something haram to make our lives miserable. He makes things haram because He knows the harm before we do. As I like to say: **the haram is always gonna do harm.**

Is Music Actually Haram?

Now you might be wondering, *“Mahnoor, what’s the evidence that music is actually haram?”* Fair question. Here you go:

IslamQA Article: “Is Music Haram?”

It includes all of the following:

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- What is Ma’azif?
- Evidence of prohibition of music and singing in the Qur’an and Sunnah
- Views of the scholars on music and singing
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- Drums at times of war and military music: An inappropriate exception
- Story of the Abyssinians playing and singing in the Prophet’s mosque
- Did the Companions listen to singing?
- Are the hadiths which forbid music full of faults?
- Singing is haram only where alcohol is drunk: Correct?
- Idle talk does not refer to singing: Correct?

- Singing is a form of worship if it helps one to obey Allah: Acceptable?
- Music softens people's hearts: Correct?
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Please, please read it with an open heart. As Muslims, our first source of guidance is the Qur'an and the authentic Sunnah. Scientific studies and statistics can help us appreciate Allah's wisdom, but they do not determine what is halal or haram. The One who created our minds, our hearts, our purpose, and our entire existence knows us better than we know ourselves. And if He tells us something is harmful... then perhaps it's because He loves us far more than we can comprehend. **Allah.**

It All Starts From the Mindset

I don't want you to look at this journey as something unpleasant. You're not "quitting music." This journey is about self-improvement. Imagine 8 billion people in this world, and Allah SWT chose you. He chose you to show you the reality of music. Now it is your turn to decide if you will accept the blessing or reject it. I pray to Allah SWT that He accepts your efforts and makes your life a journey towards betterment for His sake. Ameen.

Most of you might be thinking that I can just change later, I want to enjoy my youth right now, just wait till I turn 70. My dearest brothers and sisters, is tomorrow promised to you? Do you control your heartbeat? I too thought like you, until I saw with my own eyes and heard with my own ears. A 15-year-old named Umer Shah died when his own vomit entered his lungs, resulting in his death by the will of Allah SWT.

Over **1.5 million adolescents and young adults aged 10–24 died globally in 2021**, averaging about 4,500 deaths every day, according to the World Health Organization.

I hope that was enough to motivate you.

Now, Another Question That Needs to Be Answered Is: What Does Music Do to Our Brains?

1. The Dopamine Loop

What is dopamine? (I'll try to make it as less nerdy as possible, I promise.)

Dopamine is a chemical that is released to motivate us. It's like our own personal cheerleader. But you'll be asking: *"Hey, what's wrong in that? Isn't that a good thing?"* Well, it is—at least the real dopamine that Allah SWT put in us, for example when we:

- Push through laziness
- Stay consistent on a goal

The issue isn't dopamine, to be exact—it's where you get it from. We get our dopamine from shady places, dopamine that has been manufactured in China—the Temu kind, if you know what I mean. Instead of earning dopamine the right way, we take shortcuts. We want it fast, easy, and loads and loads of it. Of course, Shaytaan is like: *"At your service, sir/madam. One shot of music right away."*

You see the anticipation before the drop—**dopamine**. The chills you get on that beat—**dopamine**. The lyrics stuck in your head? **Dopamine**.

This might seem like it's not really that deep, but trust me, it is. Why? Because we train our brains to seek dopamine through the wrong ways, which automatically makes all the stuff that was supposed to give you healthy dopamine seem "boring." Have you noticed how life just doesn't feel so rewarding anymore? How your salah has lost khushu and Qur'an feels like a burden? Or how you'd prefer blasting music in your headphones over having to clean your

room, as the prior seems more rewarding? Or how sitting in silence or completing goals on time feels impossible now? Yeah, well, at least I did.

And it's not just music. Dopamine also spikes when:

- You binge junk food
- Watch porn
- Scroll mindlessly for hours
- Chase haram pleasures
- Take drugs, drink, or do vape

Each one is engineered to overload your brain with dopamine. But instead of motivating you to become better, they fry your focus, kill your memory, ruin your Qur'an retention, and leave your soul begging for real peace.

And the most dangerous part? You feel "good," but deep down your soul is being destroyed. That's how dopamine works, because it doesn't check if something is good for you; it just rewards whatever you repeat.

Music activates the brain's reward system

Evidence: Researchers scanned people's brains while they listened to music that gave them chills. They found dopamine release in the striatum, a key reward area of the brain. This helps explain why music can feel highly rewarding.

Reference: Salimpoor, V. N., Benovoy, M., Larcher, K., Dagher, A., & Zatorre, R. J. (2011). "Anatomically distinct dopamine release during anticipation and experience of peak emotion to music." *Nature Neuroscience*, 14(2), 257–262. DOI: 10.1038/nn.2726

2. Your Emotions? Lowkey Scripted.

Have you ever had moments where you turn on some very aesthetic sad song when you weren't even sad, and five minutes later you're questioning life, missing people you never even met, and suddenly feel like the main character that is going through some identity crisis?

Yeah, that's not random—that's your emotions being engineered. I promise.

Psychologists call it “**emotional entrainment**,” where your mood syncs with the tone of the music, even if you weren't feeling that way before. So your brain starts borrowing emotions from the song, and the more you loop it, the more it sticks.

You don't feel sad—the music makes you sad. You weren't thinking haram—the lyrics planted the thought. You weren't angry—the beat charged you up.

Scientific studies back this up:

- Lustful songs increase sexual thoughts and desire, even without any visual content.
- Aggressive music raises testosterone and impulsive behaviour, especially in young men.
- Prideful, ego-driven lyrics can literally amplify narcissistic traits, especially when repeated.

And most of the time, you won't even notice it's happening, because the song doesn't say: “*Hey, I'm brainwashing you.*” It just makes you feel something, until those feelings become your reality. So no, you're not just “vibing”—you're being emotionally programmed, one song at a time.

Music affects emotions

Evidence: Music reliably changes emotional states. Researchers found it activates emotional networks including the amygdala and limbic system.

Reference: Koelsch, S. (2014). “Brain correlates of music-evoked emotions.” *Nature Reviews Neuroscience*.

3. Memory? Focus? Worship? All Cooked.

Ever wondered why you remember the lyrics of a reel or a song instead of the actual formula at the exam centre? Like, I literally can see the page open in front of me, but when I try to recall “ $F = ma$,” all my brain is repeating is “*Baby Shark, doo doo doo...*”

Why does that even happen? Well, the answer to that question simply is: “**Earworms.**”

An earworm is a real psychological phenomenon. It's when a song, beat, or lyric gets stuck in your mind and keeps repeating itself involuntarily. It's not random; it's how the brain processes repeated audio, especially catchy music. The problem is that these repetitive loops activate your auditory cortex, and they stay lodged in your working memory—the same space your brain uses to reflect, memorize, and concentrate.

Scientifically, music, especially repetitive songs, hijacks your brain's attention resources. It competes with your mental bandwidth. And spiritually, it blocks khushu by making it harder to stay present with Allah.

Even worse, the same brain circuits that form emotional and long-term memory are triggered more by songs than speech. That's why you remember lyrics easily, but find it difficult to memorize a Surah from the Qur'an. And if you've been listening to music regularly, this pattern becomes even stronger, because what you repeat, your brain rewires to retain. So yes, those lyrics stuck in your head are the reason you feel distant from the Qur'an—not because you're weak, but because your mental space is already occupied.

You wanna know how different genres mess with your brain? Are you sureeee? Okay.

4. Earworms (Songs Stuck in Your Head)

YES. This is a real psychological phenomenon. Psychologists call them **Involuntary Musical Imagery (INMI)**.

Reference: Liikkanen, L. A. (2012). "Musical activities predispose to involuntary musical imagery." *Psychology of Music*.

5. Repetition Changes Preferences

This perfectly fits your article. Psychologists discovered **the Mere Exposure Effect**: the more people encounter something, the more familiar and often more liked it becomes.

Reference: Zajonc, R. B. (1968). "Attitudinal Effects of Mere Exposure." *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*.

6. Music Is Used for Emotion Regulation

Teenagers often use music to:

- Calm down
- Escape
- Process sadness
- Increase confidence

Reference: Saarikallio, S., & Erkkilä, J. (2007). "The role of music in adolescents' mood regulation." *Psychology of Music*.

7. Neuroplasticity

This is one of your strongest arguments. Repeated habits physically change neural pathways.

Reference: Doidge, Norman. *The Brain That Changes Itself*. 2007.

8. Music Captures Attention

Background music competes for attention, especially during reading or memorisation tasks.

Reference: Perham, N., & Currie, H. (2014). "Does listening to preferred music improve reading comprehension?" *Applied Cognitive Psychology*.

9. Lyrics Influence Thoughts

Research suggests lyrics can influence attitudes, emotions, and behaviour, particularly with repeated exposure, but effects vary by person and context.

Reference: Anderson, C. A., Carnagey, N. L., & Eubanks, J. (2003). "Exposure to violent media: The effects of songs with violent lyrics on aggressive thoughts and feelings." *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*.

10. Music and Craving

Reward circuits activated by music overlap with circuits involved in other rewarding experiences. This does not mean music is equivalent to drugs, but it helps explain why people can strongly crave listening to certain songs.

Reference: Zatorre, R. J. Various papers on music and the brain (McGill University).

4. Different Genres and Their Effects on the Brain

Rap & Trap

The bass is booming, the beat drops harder than your motivation on a Monday, and the lyrics are somewhere between “I’m the best” and “I don’t need nobody.” But here’s the kicker: it’s not just music, it’s a confidence cocktail, with a side of delusion. Here’s what’s happening in your brain:

- Every “bar” activates your dopamine system—that “feels good” chemical your brain loves a little too much.
- Aggressive or competitive lyrics boost testosterone, making you feel powerful, even if you’re literally just lying in bed with Doritos on your shirt.
- Your brain starts chasing the feeling of dominance, not real growth.

It slowly builds a personality that values image over substance, hype over heart, and flex over faith. And the worst part is that you think it’s empowering, but it’s actually replacing your confidence with arrogance and numbing your ability to feel human.

Pop

Pop music is basically that one friend who says a lot without saying anything. It’s catchy, repetitive, easy to hum, and that’s the point, because the simpler it is, the faster it loops in your head. But pop music is designed to trigger emotional highs—not real emotions, just quick hits.

Scientifically speaking:

- Its repetitive melodies activate your brain’s reward system like sugar does: instant dopamine, zero nutrition.
- The lyrics are usually vague but emotionally charged, so your brain fills in the blanks and makes the song feel personal, even when it’s not.
- And that’s how you end up dancing to heartbreak, vibing to loneliness, and smiling through pain that isn’t even yours.

Pop is emotional junk food—fun in the moment, but it trains your brain to chase emotional stimulation, not emotional depth. The result is:

- You struggle to sit with real feelings.
- You start to associate healing with distractions.
- And without realizing it, you begin to process your emotions through sound bites instead of soul work.

And that’s dangerous, because instead of confronting your own struggles, you learn to vibe them away. So it’s not just “light-hearted music”; it’s escapism disguised as entertainment.

Sad/Emo

We've all had that phase: hoodie on, lights off, and that one sad song on loop because "nobody gets me." And for a while, it feels comforting—like the song understands you. But here's what's actually going on beneath the surface:

- Sad/emo songs activate your limbic system, the emotional centre of your brain, and trigger the release of oxytocin and prolactin—hormones that soothe you during emotional pain.
- Instead of helping you move on, your brain learns to associate that pain with comfort.
- So you go back, not to heal, but to feel again.

It's a psychological trap—one that reinforces the idea that sadness is your safe space and identity. Over time, you stop chasing peace and start chasing pain you can relate to. So basically, this genre doesn't help you heal; it just teaches you to cope with sadness by replaying it, and healing becomes something you keep planning to do, but never actually start.

Metal/Rock

This is the only genre where almost every mainstream artist openly glorifies Shaytaan—not symbolically, but literally. They perform satanic rituals on stage, bathe in blood-soaked visuals, mock scripture, praise the devil in interviews, and flash occult symbols like badges of honour. The lyrics aren't poetic metaphors; they're satanic scripts. Some artists admit they didn't write them, others say the words "just came to them," and a few straight-up confessed they were written by the devil himself.

These tracks are da'wah to Jahannam, ghostwritten by the clown himself. And the music? It's loud, violent, chaotic—harsh frequencies, disturbing riffs, grotesque visuals. This isn't just sound; it's spiritual disruption. You're not being entertained; you're being invaded. This genre was built on chaos: screaming vocals, distorted guitars, rebellious lyrics. And that chaos isn't just musical—it's spiritual and psychological. It glorifies darkness, fuels rage, mocks faith, and tells your nafs that destruction is empowerment.

Here's what it does to you:

- The violent stimulation activates your body's fight-or-flight mode.
- Your brain panics at the screaming, the drumming, the imagery.
- Cortisol spikes, your heart races, and slowly, you get addicted to the adrenaline.
- You crave rage.
- You call pain "release."
- You start mistaking noise for power.

And Shaytaan? He's smiling. Because you're consuming a ritual disguised as a track, and calling it your "taste in music." In the end, this genre isn't just rebellion; rather, it's an open worship of Shaytaan. Every track is spiritually processed, taken through real satanic rituals to charge it with the energy needed to pull you in—because they know you'd never attend a devil's gathering, so they bring the ritual to you. Hidden in the riffs. Soaked in the screams. Wrapped in the lie of "art." So just to be clear: you're not just listening to music; you're indirectly participating in a ritual.

So yeah, music isn't just music. Psychologically, it's much deeper than that. Still not enough? Wanna know something cool?

I. Sound Frequencies

Every sound you hear is a vibration, and that includes music. So every beat, every bass drop, every synth is also a vibration. And your brain works on frequencies too. Scientists call them brainwaves, and they control your mental state: focus, relaxation, stress, sleep, alertness—all of it.

Now here's the catch: your brain can literally sync to external frequencies. It's called **brainwave entrainment**—when consistent rhythmic sound patterns influence your brain to match their pace. For example:

- Fast, loud beats = high-frequency brainwaves = stress, arousal, anxiety
- Slow, low-frequency beats = lower brainwaves = drowsiness, sadness, foggy thinking
- Repetitive rhythms = trance-like alpha/theta states = mental autopilot

Music producers study this. They engineer frequencies to trigger exact states of mind—to make you zone out, get hyped, or even dissociate. And just to be clear, that's not a conspiracy; it's neurological conditioning. What you think is “vibing” is actually your brain syncing to an audio pattern—sometimes uplifting, but often overstimulating, numbing, or manipulative.

II. Cognitive Hypnosis

Let's be honest: some songs are mid, but you still end up vibing to them after a few listens. Why? That's cognitive hypnosis at work. Modern music thrives on repetition—the same chorus, the same beat structure, the same rhythm looping again and again—which eventually triggers your brain's mere-exposure effect, a psychological phenomenon where you start liking something just because it feels familiar.

And nowadays, platforms like Instagram and TikTok take it further, turning 10-second audio clips into viral loops you hear 20 times a day. Add auto-tune, predictable chord progressions, and dopamine-friendly build-ups, and you've got a perfect trap. You're not choosing the song; the song is programming your preference. It's designed to bypass your attention, sneak into your memory, and stay there. That's why even when you hate a song, you catch yourself humming it days later.

III. Emotional Control

Producers layer specific frequencies with hypnotic patterns to control what you feel, when you feel it, and how long it lasts. The lyrics, the tempo, and the structure are built to evoke emotion on command. That's why songs can make you feel heartbreak you've never lived, pride you haven't earned, or lust you never sought out.

Over time, your emotions become externally controlled, as you start depending on music to feel something—anything—because your internal compass for peace, joy, or focus has been drowned in artificial emotion. And that's where the danger lies, because when your emotions are being engineered by sound, you're no longer fully in control.

So once again, very respectfully, no, it's not "just music." It's a carefully designed mix of frequency, repetition, and emotion meant to keep you hooked, programmed, and disconnected from real stillness. And unless you're aware of it, you won't even notice it's happening—not because you're weak, but because it was built to bypass your defence system altogether.

*May Allah accept your efforts and make your life a journey towards betterment for His sake. Ameen,
summa ameen.*